Northwind Logistics Employee Handbook

Version 4.2 - effective 1 January 2025. Fictional company, written as sample data for DocuMind.

Welcome to Northwind

Northwind Logistics moves freight, runs warehouses and delivers parcels across twelve countries. This handbook explains how we work together: your hours, your time off, how to travel and claim expenses, and how to keep company information safe.

The handbook applies to every permanent and fixed-term employee. Contractors follow the terms in their own agreements, but the information security rules in sections 9 and 10 apply to anyone with a Northwind account.

How to use this handbook

Each section starts with the rule and then explains the reasoning. Where a local law gives you more generous terms than this handbook, the local law wins. If something is unclear, ask your manager first and the People team second.

Policies change. The People team publishes updates on the intranet and the current version is always the one on PeopleHub, our HR system. Printed copies are for reference only.

Our values

- **Own the outcome.** If a shipment is late, we find out why and fix the cause, not just the symptom.
- **Say it early.** Problems reported early are cheap. Problems reported late are expensive.
- **Respect the road.** Safety beats speed, every time, for drivers, warehouse teams and office staff alike.
- **Keep it simple.** We prefer clear processes that people actually follow over clever ones that nobody remembers.

1. Working hours and attendance

The standard working week is 40 hours, Monday to Friday. Northwind uses flexible hours: you choose when to start and finish, provided you are available during the core hours of 10:00 to 16:00 local time and your team's coverage needs are met.

Warehouse and transport staff work on rostered shifts instead. Shift patterns are published at least 14 days in advance, and swaps must be approved by the shift lead in the rostering tool.

Hybrid and remote work

Office-based employees may work remotely for up to 3 days per week. Teams agree a shared "anchor day" when everyone is in the office. Working fully remotely, or from another country for more than 10 working days in a year, needs written approval from your director and the People team because of tax and immigration rules.

Overtime

Overtime must be agreed with your manager before it is worked. Eligible employees are paid at 1.5 times their hourly rate on weekdays and 2 times on Sundays and public holidays. Employees on management grades are not paid overtime but may take time off in lieu by agreement.

Absence reporting

If you cannot come to work, tell your manager by phone or chat before your start time, or no later than 09:30 for flexible-hours staff. A message to a colleague is not enough. Unreported absence for three consecutive days is treated as unauthorised.

2. Annual leave

Full-time employees receive 25 days of paid annual leave per calendar year, plus public holidays. Part-time employees receive a pro-rata amount based on their contracted hours.

Leave accrues monthly at 2.08 days per month. New joiners can take leave they have already accrued; taking leave before it has accrued (borrowing ahead) needs your manager's approval and is limited to 5 days.

Long-service leave

After five years of continuous service you receive 2 extra days of annual leave per year. After ten years you receive 5 extra days per year.

Carrying leave over

You may carry over up to 5 unused days into the next calendar year. Carried-over days must be used by 31 March, after which they expire. Days beyond the 5-day limit are lost on 31 December unless a director approves an exception because business needs prevented you from taking them.

Selling and buying leave

Once per year, during the January benefits window, you may buy up to 5 extra days of leave through salary sacrifice. Northwind does not buy back unused leave except when you leave the company, when accrued but untaken days are paid out in your final salary.

3. Sick leave and family leave

Sick leave

Employees receive up to 10 days of fully paid sick leave per calendar year. For absences longer than 3 consecutive calendar days you must provide a medical certificate (a doctor's note). After the 10 paid days are used, statutory sick pay applies.

Long-term illness is handled case by case with the People team and our occupational health partner. Our priority is a safe, gradual return to work.

Parental leave

The primary caregiver receives 20 weeks of parental leave at full pay. The secondary caregiver receives 6 weeks at full pay, which can be taken in up to three blocks within the first 12 months after the birth or adoption. These terms apply equally to adoption and surrogacy.

You should notify the People team at least 15 weeks before the expected due date, or as soon as an adoption match is confirmed.

Bereavement and compassionate leave

You may take up to 5 days of paid bereavement leave on the death of a close family member, and up to 2 days for other relatives. Managers may grant additional compassionate leave for serious family emergencies.

Volunteering

Every employee may take 2 paid volunteering days per year for a registered charity or community project.

4. Public holidays and requesting time off

Northwind observes the public holidays of the country where your employment contract is held. The list for each country is published on PeopleHub each November for the following year. If you are required to work on a public holiday you receive a replacement day off in addition to holiday pay.

How to request leave

All leave is requested in PeopleHub. Please give at least 2 weeks' notice for leave of up to 5 days and at least 4 weeks' notice for longer periods. Your manager should respond within 3 working days. Approved leave is visible in the team calendar automatically.

Blackout periods

Some teams have blackout periods when leave is normally not approved:

- **Finance:** the last two weeks of December and the first week of July (year-end and half-year close).
- **Warehouse operations:** from 15 November to 24 December (peak season).
- **Customer support:** the week of any major system migration, announced at least 6 weeks ahead.

Exceptions for weddings, medical treatment and similar events are always considered.

Unpaid leave and sabbaticals

Employees with more than three years of service may request a sabbatical of 1 to 3 months unpaid. Your role is held for you, and benefits such as health insurance continue during the sabbatical.

5. Business travel: booking and approval

Travel should be necessary. Before booking, consider whether a video call would achieve the same result.

Approval

- **Domestic trips** need approval from your line manager.
- **International trips** need approval from your director, and must be requested at least 14 days before departure where possible.
- Trips longer than 10 nights need approval from the department head.

Booking

All flights, trains and hotels are booked through TripDesk, our corporate travel portal. Bookings made outside TripDesk are only reimbursed when TripDesk had no availability or was more expensive, and you must attach evidence of the TripDesk price.

Class of travel

- Rail is preferred for journeys under 4 hours.
- Flights are economy class by default.
- Premium economy is allowed for flights over 6 hours.
- **Business class** is allowed only for flights with a scheduled flight time of more than 8 hours, or with a medical certificate.

Travel insurance and safety

All employees on approved business travel are covered by the corporate travel insurance policy. Download the policy card from PeopleHub before you leave. For trips to countries on the company's elevated-risk list, you must complete the travel security briefing and register your itinerary with the security team.

6. Business travel: per diem and accommodation

Northwind pays a daily allowance, called the per diem, to cover meals and incidental costs while you travel. You do not need receipts for costs covered by the per diem.

Trip type	Per diem (per day)	Hotel cap (per night)
Domestic	USD 55	USD 180
International	USD 85	USD 250
High-cost cities (London, New York, Zurich, Tokyo)	USD 110	USD 320

Rules for the per diem

- On the first and last day of a trip you receive 75% of the daily rate.
- If a meal is provided (for example by a client or included in a conference fee), the per diem is reduced by 20% for breakfast and 30% each for lunch or dinner.
- Day trips of more than 10 hours without an overnight stay receive 50% of the domestic rate.

Accommodation

Hotel bookings above the nightly cap need approval in TripDesk before you travel. Staying with friends or family instead of a hotel is welcome; you can then claim a flat accommodation allowance of USD 40 per night.

Ground transport

Use public transport where it is practical. Taxis and ride-hailing are reimbursed for travel to and from airports, late at night (after 21:00) or when carrying heavy equipment. Car hire needs prior approval and must be the smallest suitable category.

7. Expenses: claiming and reimbursement

You can claim costs that you pay personally while doing your job, as long as they are reasonable and necessary.

How to claim

Submit claims in the Expenses module of PeopleHub within 30 days of the date the cost was incurred. Claims submitted after 90 days are not paid except in exceptional circumstances approved by Finance.

- An itemised receipt is required for every expense of USD 25 or more.
- Below USD 25, a short description is enough, but Finance may ask for evidence in an audit.
- Photographs of receipts are accepted; you do not need to keep the paper original unless local tax law requires it.

Mileage

When you use your own car for business travel, you can claim USD 0.62 per mile (USD 0.39 per kilometre). Commuting between home and your normal workplace is not business travel. Record the start point, end point and purpose of each journey.

Reimbursement timing

Approved claims are paid with the next payroll run, and at the latest within 10 business days of approval. Your manager approves claims up to USD 1,000; larger claims are also approved by Finance.

Currency

Expenses in a foreign currency are converted at the rate shown on your card statement, or at the TripDesk daily rate when you paid in cash.

8. Expenses: corporate cards and non-reimbursable items

Corporate card

Employees who travel more than four times a year can apply for a Northwind corporate card. The card must only be used for business expenses. Personal use, even if repaid, is a disciplinary matter. The monthly limit is USD 5,000 unless Finance approves more. Every card transaction must be matched with a receipt in PeopleHub within 30 days.

Client entertainment

Entertaining clients is allowed when it supports a clear business purpose. The limit is USD 120 per person, including drinks, and the names of attendees and their companies must be recorded on the claim. Entertainment of public officials needs approval from the Legal team beforehand.

Items that are not reimbursed

- Alcohol, except as part of approved client entertainment.
- Hotel minibar items, in-room films and laundry on trips shorter than 5 nights.
- Traffic fines, parking penalties and speeding tickets.
- Upgrades to flights, hotel rooms or hire cars that are outside this policy.
- Personal grooming, gym fees, and lost personal property.
- Travel for spouses, partners or family members.

Mistakes and misuse

If you make an honest mistake on a claim, correct it as soon as you notice. Deliberately false claims are treated as gross misconduct.

9. Information security: accounts and data

Everyone with a Northwind account is responsible for protecting company and customer information.

Passwords and sign-in

- Passwords must be at least 14 characters long. We recommend a passphrase of four or more random words.
- Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is mandatory for email, PeopleHub, TripDesk and all customer systems.
- Never share your password, and never approve an MFA prompt you did not start.
- Use the company password manager; do not reuse your Northwind password anywhere else.

Data classification

Every document and dataset falls into one of four classes:

Class	Examples	Handling
Public	Press releases, website content	No restrictions
Internal	Org charts, this handbook	Northwind staff only
Confidential	Customer contracts, pricing	Need-to-know, encrypted in transit
Restricted	Payroll, health data, security keys	Named individuals only, encrypted at rest

Phishing

If you receive a suspicious email, do not click links or open attachments. Report it with the "Report phishing" button or by forwarding it to security@northwind.example within 1 hour. If you already clicked, report it immediately: speed matters more than embarrassment, and nobody is disciplined for reporting quickly.

10. Information security: devices and remote work

Company devices

Laptops are issued with full-disk encryption and endpoint protection already installed. Do not disable them. Your screen must lock automatically after 5 minutes of inactivity, and you should lock it manually whenever you step away.

USB storage devices are blocked on company laptops. Use the approved file-sharing service to exchange files with customers and partners.

Working away from the office

- Always connect through the company VPN when using public or hotel Wi-Fi.
- Do not work on Restricted data in public places such as trains or cafes.
- Use a privacy screen filter when travelling; these can be ordered from the IT portal.

Lost or stolen devices

Report a lost or stolen laptop or phone to the IT Helpdesk within 24 hours, by phone on extension 4357 (HELP) or at +1 555 0100 4357 from outside the network. IT will lock and wipe the device remotely. You will not be charged for a lost device unless it was lost through gross negligence.

Personal devices

You may read email and chat on a personal phone after enrolling it in the mobile device management app. Company data on personal devices is kept in a separate work profile that IT can wipe without touching your personal data.

11. Code of conduct and contacts

Gifts and hospitality

You may accept gifts from suppliers or customers worth up to USD 50 in total per year from the same source. Anything above that must be declared in the gifts register within 5 working days and may need to be returned. Cash and cash equivalents such as gift cards are never acceptable.

Conflicts of interest

Declare any personal relationship, investment or side job that could influence your decisions at work. Declaring is not an admission of wrongdoing; it lets us manage the situation openly.

Speaking up

If you see behaviour that breaks the law or this handbook, raise it with your manager, the People team or Legal. You can also report anonymously through the independent Speak Up hotline, available 24 hours a day in all of our languages. Northwind does not tolerate retaliation against anyone who raises a concern in good faith.

Key contacts

Topic	Contact
People team (HR)	people@northwind.example
IT Helpdesk	extension 4357
Security incidents	security@northwind.example
Travel desk	TripDesk chat, or travel@northwind.example
Speak Up hotline	speakup.northwind.example

Thank you for reading. Welcome aboard.